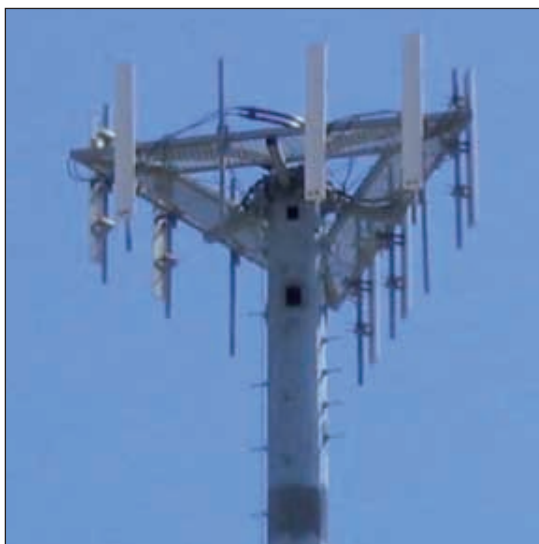




A GSM cellular tower top

such as international roaming to be easily implemented. The fact that the network specifications of the phone are obtained through a SIM (Subscriber Identification Module) card allows users to switch handsets at will, by just moving the SIM to another handset. GSM is the undeniable market leader in mobile phone technologies today, and is expected to remain in this position until 3G takes over.

The origins of GSM date back to the year 1987 when 13 European countries came together in the signing of a memorandum of understanding to develop a common, uniform interoperable cellular telephone standard. The responsibility was soon entrusted to the European Telecommunications Standardization Institute (ETSI) in 1989 which was followed by the publication of the GSM standard in 1990. Further updated versions were published later. One of the primary distinguishing features of GSM was the fact that all features of it were digital. This made it future compatible and capable of later adopting features such as data communication. By 1993, the standard had been updated to support short messaging service (SMS). In 1997, the standard included general packet radio services